LoopCasts

The website and hosting

LoopCasts BV · Ghent
Internal document. Please do not share outside the team.
Handbook chapter 02

LOOPCASTS HANDBOOK · CHAPTER 02

The website and hosting

Internal handbook, chapter 2. Written by Tom. I am only in on Tuesday and Thursday, so read this before you call me.

What the website is

`loopcasts.example` is a normal website: HTML, CSS and a little JavaScript. No CMS. I know, I know. In 2019 it was 6 pages and a CMS felt like overkill. Now it is about 140 pages, because every course has its own page and every video has its own page inside the members area.

There are two parts:

1. **The public site**: home, course overview, a page per course, pricing, about, contact.
2. **The members area** (`/members`): a PHP script that Jens wrote in 2019. It checks your e-mail and password against a MySQL table and then shows the video pages. It works. Nobody here really understands it. We do not touch it.

Where the files are

The real website is on the server. My copy is on my laptop in `Documents/loopcasts-site`. Pieter also has a copy because he sometimes fixes typos when I am not in. Yasmine has an older copy for the landing pages.

So the rule is: **before you change anything, download the latest version from the server with FileZilla.** Otherwise you overwrite somebody's work. This happened in March with the pricing page (the old prices were online for four days, a customer noticed).

When I change something big I keep the old file, so you will see things like:

```
index.html
index_old.html
index_final.html
index_final_v3.html
pricing_NEW_use_this_one.html
```

Please do not delete these. I am not sure which ones are still linked.

How a change goes online

1. Download the latest files from the server (FileZilla, the login is in the passwords file, see chapter 7).
2. Edit the HTML in your editor.
3. Open the file in your browser to check it.

4. Upload the changed files with FileZilla. Do not forget the images.
5. Open the real site and check again. Press Ctrl+F5, the cache is stubborn.

There is no test site. If it is broken, it is broken live, so I try not to do this on Friday afternoon.

Testing the members area locally

This is a pain. The members area needs PHP and MySQL. I use MAMP with PHP 7.4 because that is what the server had in 2019. Pieter has XAMPP on Windows with PHP 8.2, and there the login page gives warnings. On Yasmine's Mac it does not start at all. The server itself was upgraded by the host last year to PHP 8.1, I think. We found out because the contact form stopped working.

For a new colleague, getting the site to run locally takes me about half a day, if I am in.

A new course page

When Pieter has a new course, he mails me the title, the description, the list of videos and the Vimeo embed codes. Then I:

1. Copy the page of an existing course and rename it.
2. Replace the title, description, thumbnail and price.
3. Make a page for every video inside `/members` (also copy-paste) and paste the embed code.
4. Add the course to the course overview page **and** to the home page if it is new **and** to the sitemap.
5. Upload everything.

A course with 12 videos takes me about two hours. The list of courses also lives in Pieter's Excel (the catalogue, see chapter 4). The website and the Excel do not always say the same thing. The Excel is supposed to be right.

Twice a week a new video goes live. That is a smaller job: one new page, one link on the course page. About 20 minutes, but it has to happen on Tuesday and Friday, and I am not in on Friday, so I prepare the Friday page on Thursday and Pieter uploads it.

The order button

On the pricing page, the "Order" buttons are `mailto:` links. They open the customer's mail program with a mail to `orders@` and a subject like "Order: yearly subscription". The customer types their details in the mail. Lotte takes it from there (chapter 3).

We talked about a real order form. It is on the whiteboard.

Hosting

Shared hosting at a Belgian host, the € 9 a month package. It includes the domain, the mailboxes, FTP, PHP and one MySQL database. Things to know:

- There is a limit of 100 recipients per e-mail (Yasmine knows all about this, chapter 5).
- The host makes backups, but we never tried to restore one.
- The SSL certificate renews by itself now. Until 2022 I did it by hand every year and I forgot once.

Things I would like, one day

- Not being the only one who can put things online.
- Knowing who changed what, and when.
- A test site.
- Never copy-pasting a video page again.